

The flying tanks of D-Day

The idea of carrying tanks by air dates back to the early 1930s, but it was not achieved until 1944—D-Day. On the morning of June 6, a few tanks were flown from an airfield in southern England and landed on the French coast near the mouth of the Orne river. The tanks were Tetrarch Light Tanks (see p.92) and the aircraft were Hamilcar Gliders.

The Hamilcar was a large aircraft for its time, with a wingspan of 110ft (34m) and a weight of around 7 tons (6.3 tonnes). Built almost entirely of wood, it required a crew of two. It dropped its undercarriage on takeoff and landed on skids—as soon as the glider stopped, the tank started up and, as it moved forward, it activated a rope that opened the nose door.

On D-Day, each Hamilcar carried either a pair of Universal Carriers (see p.122) or one Tetrarch. Hamilcars were used again on the Rhine Crossing in March 1945, in this case carrying US Locust light tanks. Built in the US to replace the Tetrarch, the Locust had many growing pains, and by the time it reached Europe it was too weak to be of much use. Of the eight tanks used in the Rhine crossing, one was lost as a glider broke up in flight, three were damaged on landing, and another was rapidly knocked out by a German assault gun.

A Locust light tank disembarks from the folding nose of a Hamilcar glider in 1944.

